

# **VIP NOTEBOOK**

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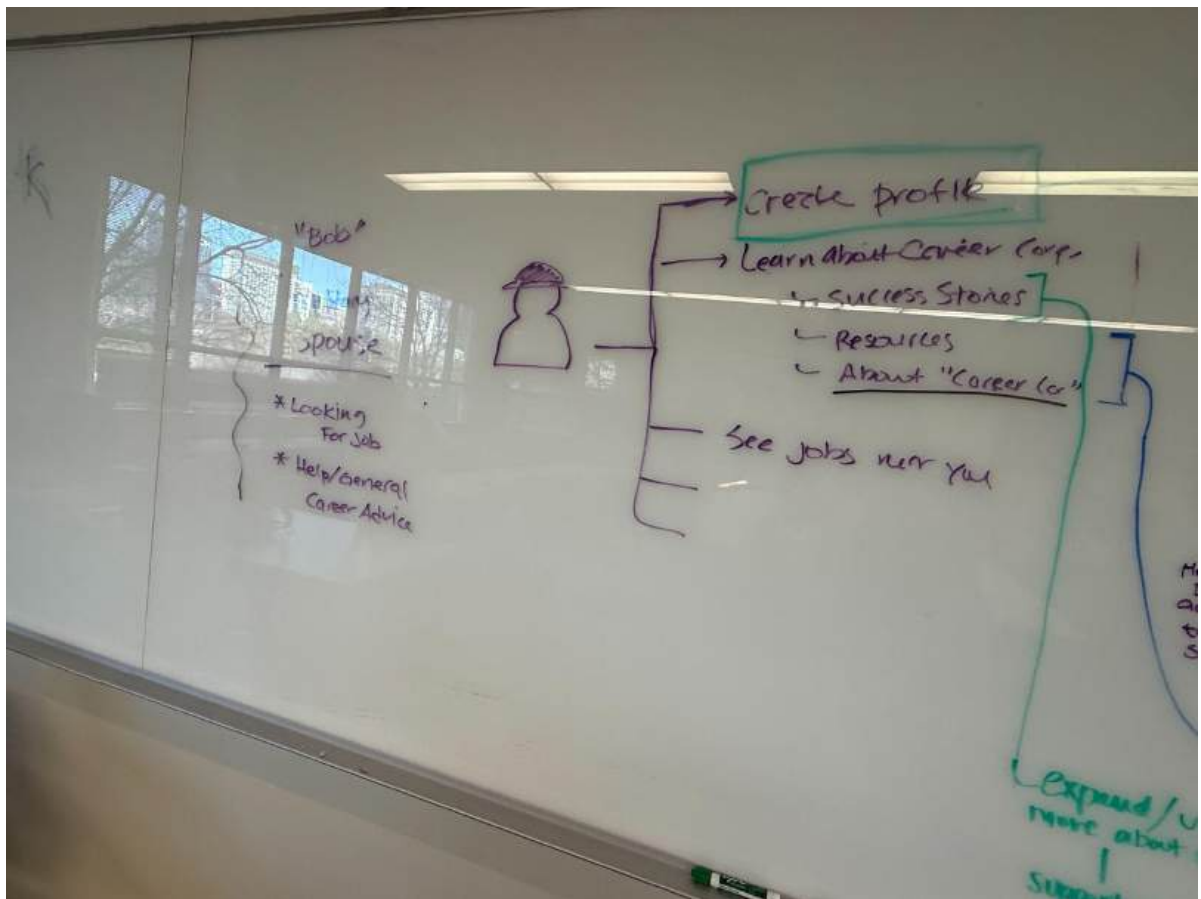
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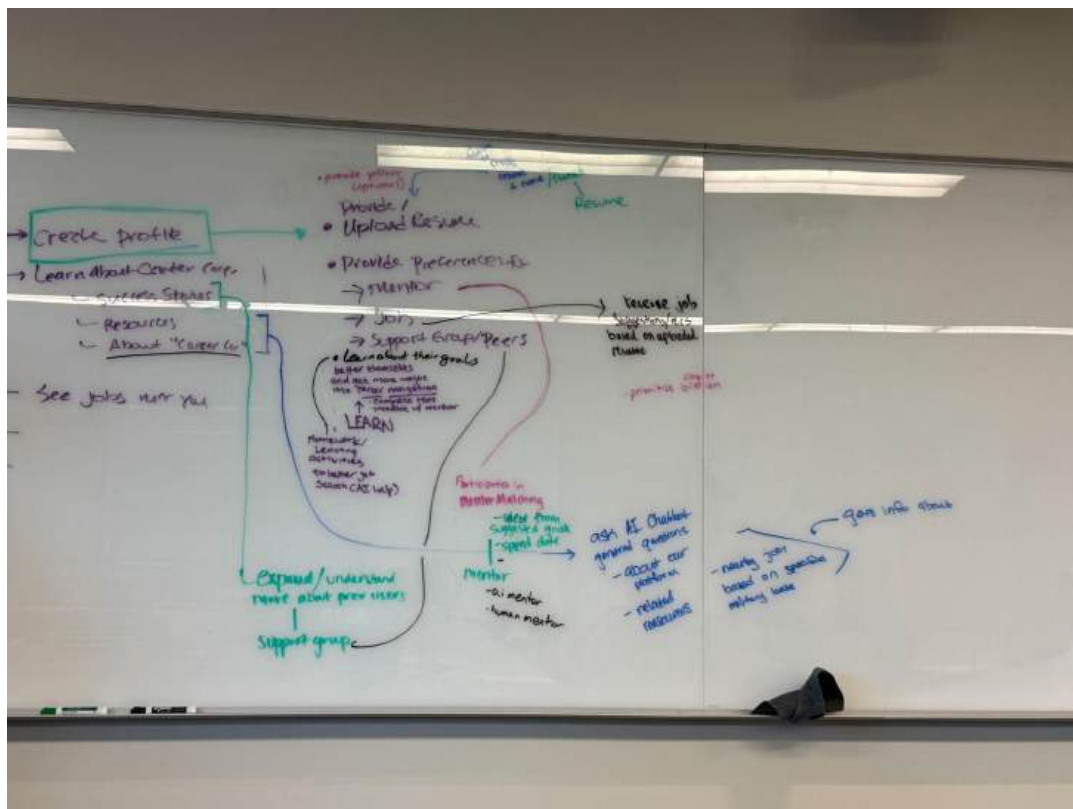
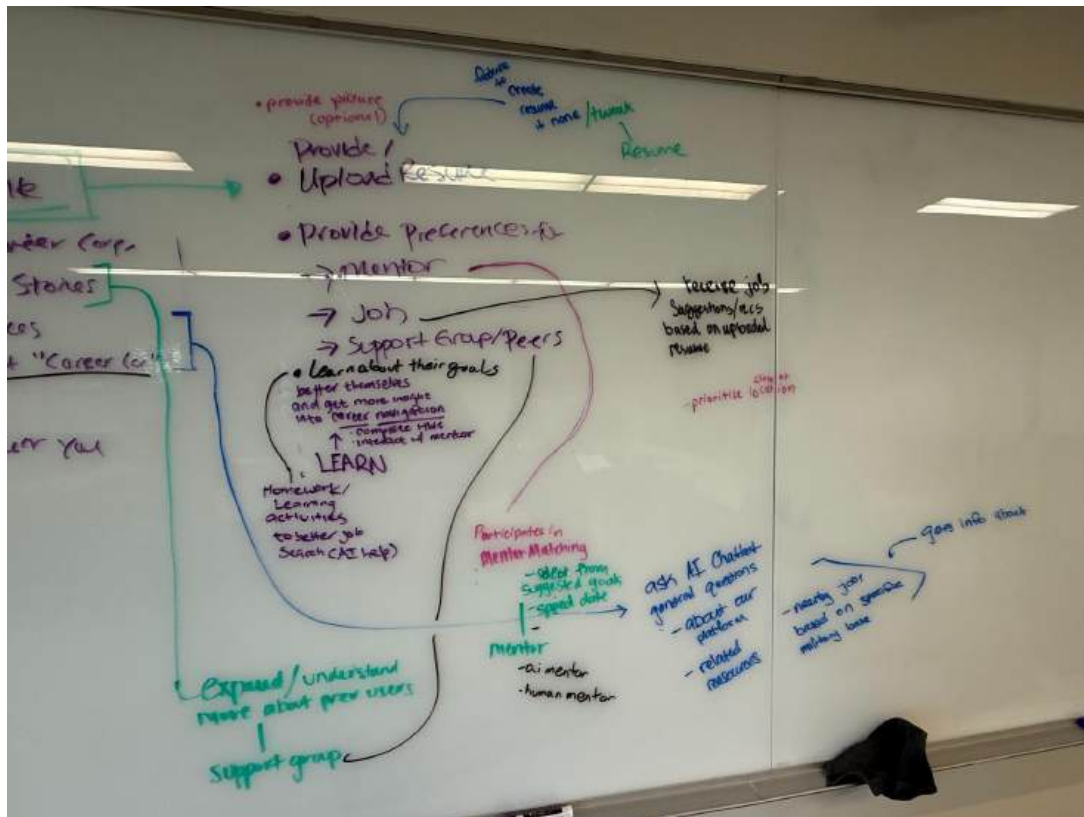
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## January 13, 2026: First Meeting with VIP

### Class:

- Today, I was not in class, but I discussed what I missed with other classmates.
- In class, they made a mindmap.
- The mindmap went through Bob, who is a military spouse that is looking for a job and needs help/general career advice.
- It goes through the steps of how he would interact with our career corp app. These include creating a profile, learning about career corp, and seeing jobs near you.
- Images of the mindmap:





**To Do List:**

- Provide a paragraph describing the vision of the career corp tool, what is the core goal of the app. What are we trying to solve?
  - Broaden the user base
- We made a mindmap in class, so we should grow it in some direction with a tool we do not already have.
- This should be a lot of brainstorming.
- It can be in the form of a diagram, figma, or other options.
- What is the goal of "Career Corp" from your point of view? What are the purposes and goals? Secondly, what would you add to Career Corp to further those goals that haven't already been created?

**Work on To Do:**

- What I Did:
  - This week I put into one paragraph what I thought the goal of the app would be. This would be what I would put in the about page for the app.
- What went well/what didn't:
  - It was easy to think of all the goals of the app, but it was a little difficult to put the whole thing into one small paragraph that would go on an "About" page. I was able to get it down to a paragraph by focusing on what our core values would be.
  - I also just drew the diagram for the community page, which made sense to me, but I think in the future, I would do a Figma as this would be cleaner and make more sense to others too.
- Connection to overall class:
  - This helps us focus and start out this semester by having a clear idea about what the goal of our app is. It also gives a place to start for how to add onto the app and get started for the semester.
- Results:
  - Slack post:

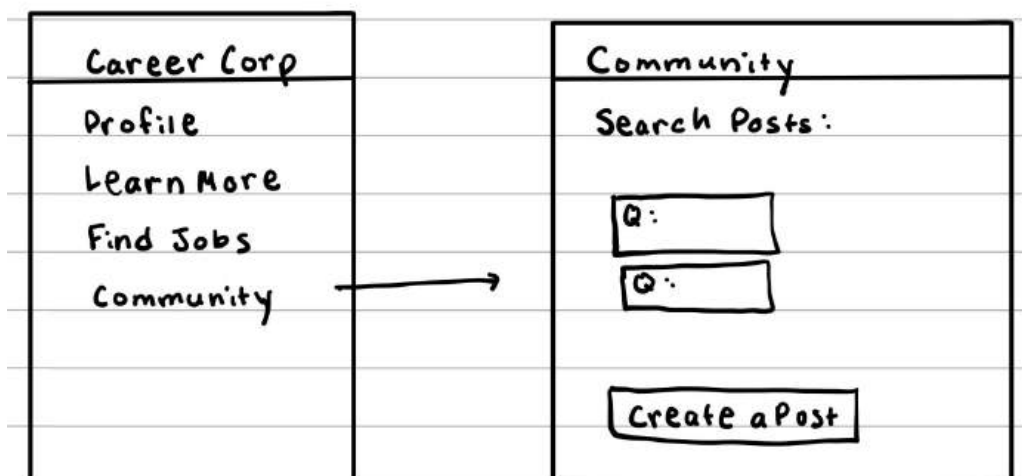
**Goal/Purpose**

Career Corp is a career support app designed for military spouses, keeping in mind that they have to relocate frequently, leading to disruptions in their career and less access to close professional networks. The goal of the app is to provide military spouses with jobs through mentorship, along with giving them access to a community of professionals and others in similar positions all in one app. Rather than a normal job finding website, Career Corp not only helps with finding open job opportunities, but also provides mentorship on how to develop and land that job and support from other military spouses. This ultimately helps military spouses build long term careers by connecting them with mentors, resources, and a network of people, rather than just finding them a temporary job. Overall, I think there should be emphasis on combining all of these into one app.

#### **Addition to Further Goals**

To further these goals, I would add a separate community page on the main screen of the app. In the mindmap, there's a section on success stories to connect with peers, but I think we should aim to keep spouses on the app even after finding a job to further the community aspect of the app. The community aspect can be almost like a Reddit feed, where spouses can ask questions, and get responses from other military spouses who have gone through the same experience. This is similar to what one of the groups had in their prototype for last semester but was not implemented. I think it's important to put emphasis on the community aspect of the app. I think to further the idea even more, we could also have an AI suggested answer to the questions, so that the person can get an immediate output while waiting for other community members to answer.

#### **Diagram:**



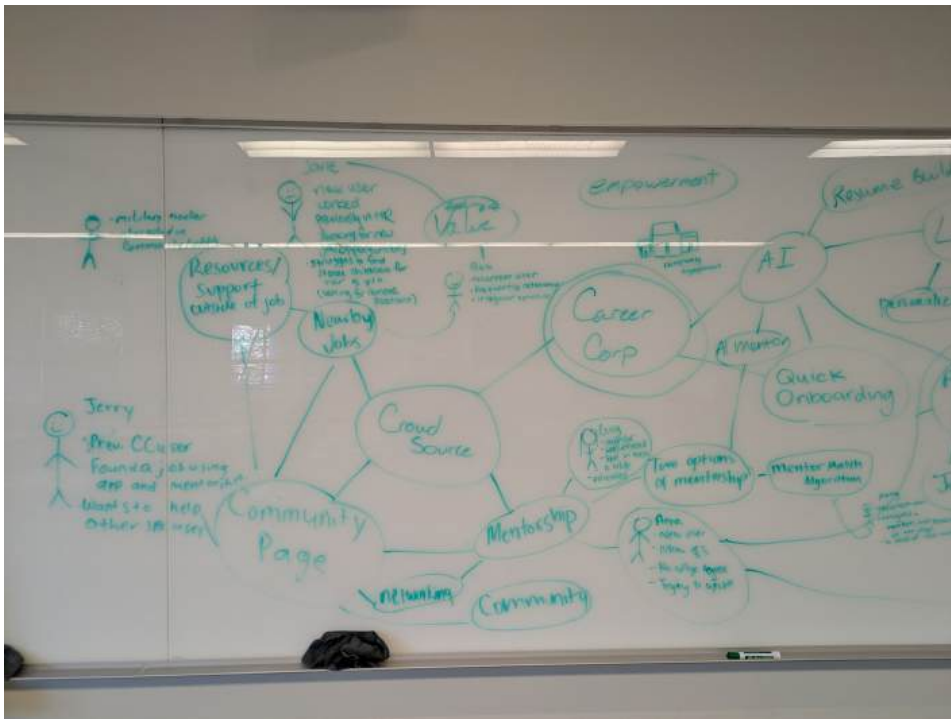
- Completion Date:
  - 1/20/26

## January 20, 2026: Discussing About Page

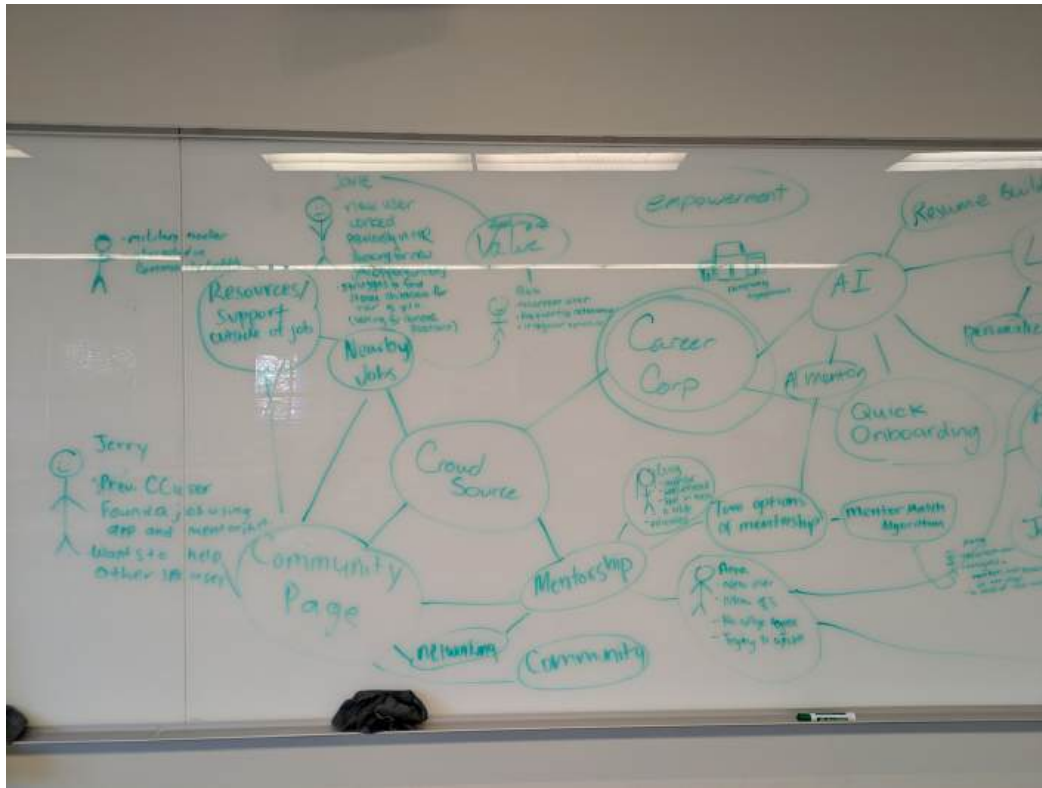
### Class:

- We will build a mindmap around Career Corp and what we did last time with the about page.
- Career Corp is the central app and we have things branching out of it.
- This will help us understand what the app is about and connect ideas to each other.
- We put up all the current features we have and the personas we have in the app. This helped us see our core values like mentorship, jobs, community, and skill building.
- We also discussed potential new ideas we can add to the app that we currently do not have.
  - In person support groups.
  - Recruit currently employed military spouses.
  - Wider net of support (childcare, sports, etc).
  - Company engagement (career fairs sponsored by previously successful military spouses).

- What would users want to get out of an in person support group?
  - Making new local connections in the area.
  - Gives a sense of empowerment for new spouses that are new in the area that have been in their shoes and have been successful.
- Recruit currently employed military spouses:
  - Similarly gives empowerment and hope by seeing people in their shoes.
  - What would make these people want to participate?
- Company engagement:
  - Why would companies want to engage? To hire and get good people.
  - Our primary audience would like to know there are a lot of different resources to get different jobs, not just a job board. A career event helps with this.
  - Companies may also want to help with the mentoring piece.
- Wider network of support:
  - This helps break the ice.
  - This may also help the spouses get a third place to meet more people.
- Images of mindmap and brainstorming:







- In person support group
- Recruit currently employed military spouses
- Wider net of support (childcare, local support, sports)
- Company engagement (Career fairs - best by current spouse employee)

### To Do List:

- Continue to think about the brainstorming we did in this class.
- Create a simple mockup of the four new ideas we discussed in class.
  - What things are going to make these new ideas hard.
  - Do research on which of these features already exist or are already supported.
- In two weeks, we want to have a concrete idea of what we are building for this semester.

- Right now we can think of new things. Broad and big new things.
- Maybe we want to take some of the things we built and take them on a test run.

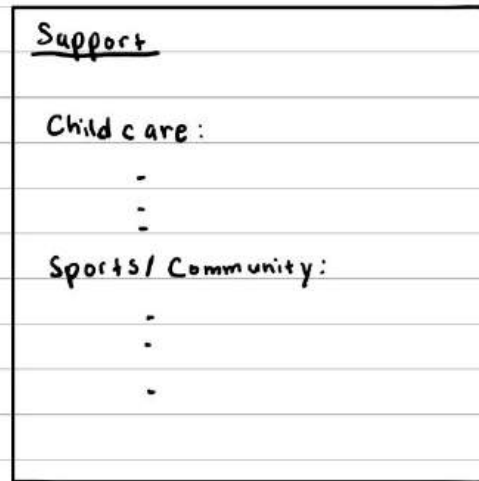
### **Work on To Do:**

- What I Did:
  - Based on the four ideas we had brainstormed from last class, I started by drawing what this would look like in app form. I also thought about how it would like for our different user groups to interact with these features in the app, and I wrote those down.
  - After I came up with hand drawn mockups of the four new ideas, I began researching how they may already exist and noted those as well.
  - These made my big overarching ideas for the future of the app.
- What went well/what didn't:
  - I think creating the actual mockups went well, they were a rough idea of the app. I also was able to combine some of the ideas into pages of the app by drawing this out.
  - Something important that came from the research was that a lot of our existing ideas in the app already exist through government ideas, so I think for our future, it is better for us to think of something new or create something better than what exists.
  - So something to work on is possibly finding feedback from spouses as to what other tools they would want or what the existing issues with the existing tools are.
- Connection to overall class:
  - This created my ideas for where we would go with the app for this semester, so it is bringing us closer to what we will be working on. I think this combined with the rest of the classes ideas will help determine what direction we will go in for the app.
- Results:
- **In person Support Group and Recruit Currently Employed Military Spouses Mockup:**

| In Person Support Groups: | Recruit Currently Employed Spouses: |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Location: _____           | <u>Become a Mentor:</u>             |
| Radius: _____             | Current role:                       |
| Upcoming Meetings:        | Industry:                           |
| _____ Join                | Can help with:                      |
| _____ Join                | Availability:                       |
| _____ Join                | <u>Add an event:</u>                |

- 
- For the in person support groups, there would be a page on the app dedicated to events. I decided to combine this with the company engagement idea. I think companies can also add their events to this page too, so it is not too confusing and all the events would be on one page.
- For currently employed spouses, there can be a page that allows them to enter the app as a user. I also decided that they should have functionality that goes with the previous mockup, where they get the ability to add an event. I would also have a similar page for adding a company to the app. They could similarly add their details and their events, like career fairs to the app.
- **Research:** <https://veteranspousenetwork.org/> This website community of peer support for military and veteran spouses, so this is very similar to the idea we are trying to create with the in person support groups.
- <https://myseco.militaryonesource.mil/portal/article/military-spouse-career-mentoring-programs> This source also finds mentors for military spouses, so we can try to find mentors in a similar way to this.
- **Wider Net of Support Mockup:**

### Wider Net of Support:



- For the wider net of support idea, I think this would just be a page on the app with links to resources and maybe even blog posts that other spouses write. This would be similar to the page we have that shows what the app is about.
- **Research:** There are many online resources that provide resources for this, but I think we can take all these resources and put them in one place on the app.
- **Company Engagement Mockup:**
- I decided to have the Company Engagement Mockup as part of the In Person Support Group Mockup, as mentioned above.
- **Research:** Since a lot of spouses have a college degree, they can also go back to their colleges as alumni and attend the career fair to network.  
<https://msejobs.militaryonesource.mil/msep/> This is an existing source, where they connect employers with military spouses, which already exists.
- Completion Date:
  - 1/27/26

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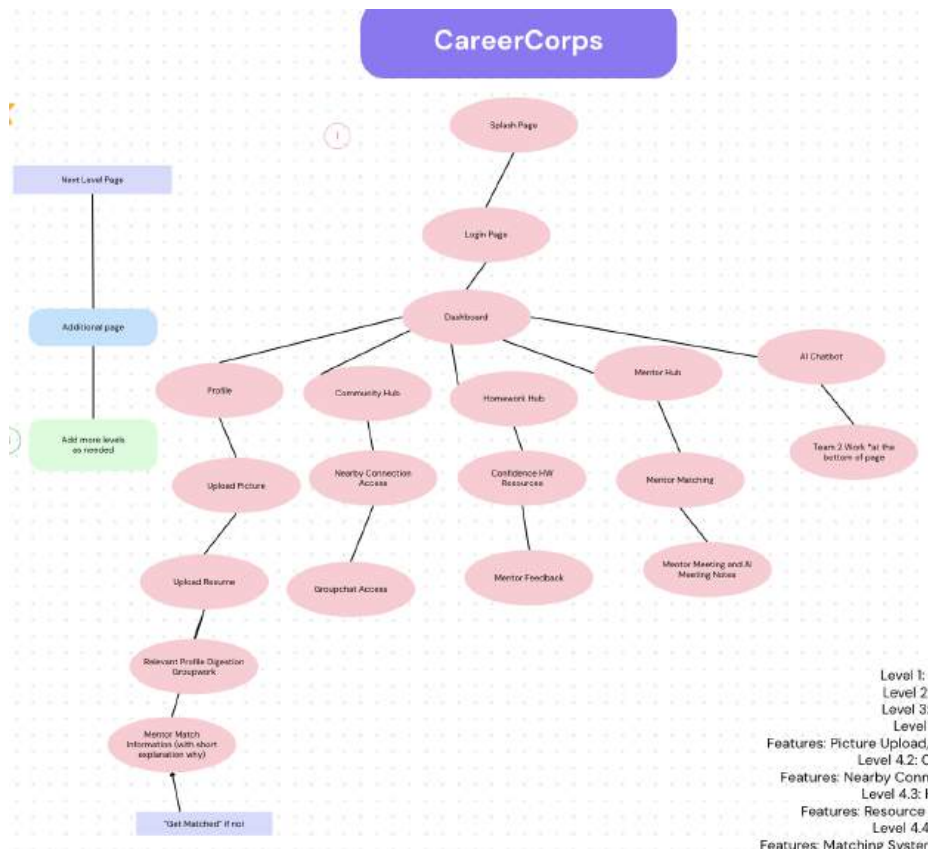
## January 27, 2026: Deciding on Big Idea for App Future

**Class:**

- Today, we started with discussing the big ideas we thought of over the week.
- We are deciding on a future direction for the app for the semester.
- Some of the keywords we came up with:
  - Gamified Interactions
    - Scoring mentors/coaches: badges, money, reputation
    - Community - reputation
    - Spouses - goals, events attended
  - Events and Community
    - Career fairs
      - How do we motivate people to put together and organize the events?
    - Employer connections
    - Community groups
  - Interviews with Spouses
    - Research needs for a platform
  - Career Confidence Builder
    - Progress bar for spouses
    - Interest in spouse
    - Enhancing resume/profile
  - Successful Stories
    - Highlighting those who used Career Corp successfully
    - Connect these people with those still looking
- Interesting podcast: This is Uncomfortable - It is helpful to build a community
- For inspiration and ideas:
 

<https://www.marketplace.org/episode/2026/01/15/surviving-job-hunting-hell>
- How do you motivate and build community around this difficult and isolating experience?
- All of these ideas have a crowdsourcing aspect, but how would we bring this to AI too?
- Should we focus more on the crowd aspect of this and creating community over looking inwards with the mentor?

- Looking at the crowd aspect: we want to form strong bonds with this, where social media currently only forms weak bonds.
- We should have some type of notification system to keep people in the app.
  - Notify about a new success story, notify about mentions in the community page.
- How will this app be different from what already exists?
  - It seems like a combination of Reddit, Slack, LinkedIn.
  - So it is an all in one, one stop shop type of app.
- We can also lean into more of what we did last semester.
  - We made some assumptions, maybe we will remove those.
  - Can we test our work? This should be an aspect we should look back at.
- Is there other research that we can explore to see other avenues?
- A way to decide: We should pitch our idea based on all the ideas we have discussed so far.
  - Your goal should be to convince everyone in the room that your idea is the direction you want to move in.
- Here is a map Anita made of what we had mostly from last semester:



- 
- Something we could do is combine the last three parts, Homework Hub, Mentor Hub, and AI Chatbot

### To Do List:

- We should look at our old ideas and think of ways to continue forward with them, or maybe think of new research avenues to go with it.
- We could also look at brand new ideas we have not thought of yet.
- Overall, we should come with even more new ideas.

### Work on To Do:

- What I Did:
  - I thought about what I would want to work on for the rest of the semester, and what I thought would be the most useful direction to go in. I also looked back at our final presentation from last semester to see what future directions we had mentioned there. Based on this, I was able to create a paragraph pitch.

- What went well/what didn't:
    - I think it was easy to remember what we did last semester and to see the future directions of our ideas. This helped to generate my pitch for this semester.
    - It was harder to think of newer ideas without having a working app, so I suggest creating a cohesive app first as part of my pitch.
  - Connection to overall class:
    - This moves us forward with my idea of where I think we should go as a class, so we are getting closer to finalizing what we want to work on for the semester.
  - Results:
    - Pitch:
    - I think our direction this semester should be to unify the three groups from last semester into a single, cohesive website or application that supports the full career lifecycle for military spouses, from initial career exploration through job placement and long term help. The platform will be structured around pages that are features. These include the features that all our groups had from last time like AI mentorship, professional mentorship, community discussion, job matching, and other support. I think we should also have multiple complete user flows implemented. We will have different flows and views for spouses and mentors. Beyond building a prototype, we should also test out how supportive and engaging this app will be. This could be similar to two semesters ago when we made forms to get feedback. So I think there should be some testing involved, which we didn't do last time. I think that once we have a single app and some testing, then we can go onto adding additional, more engaging features that draw people to our app based on feedback. This can include things like the gamified interactions we were discussing last class. I think this combines both the individual and community aspects from last class, and we are not just focusing on one.
  - Completion Date:
    - 2/3/26
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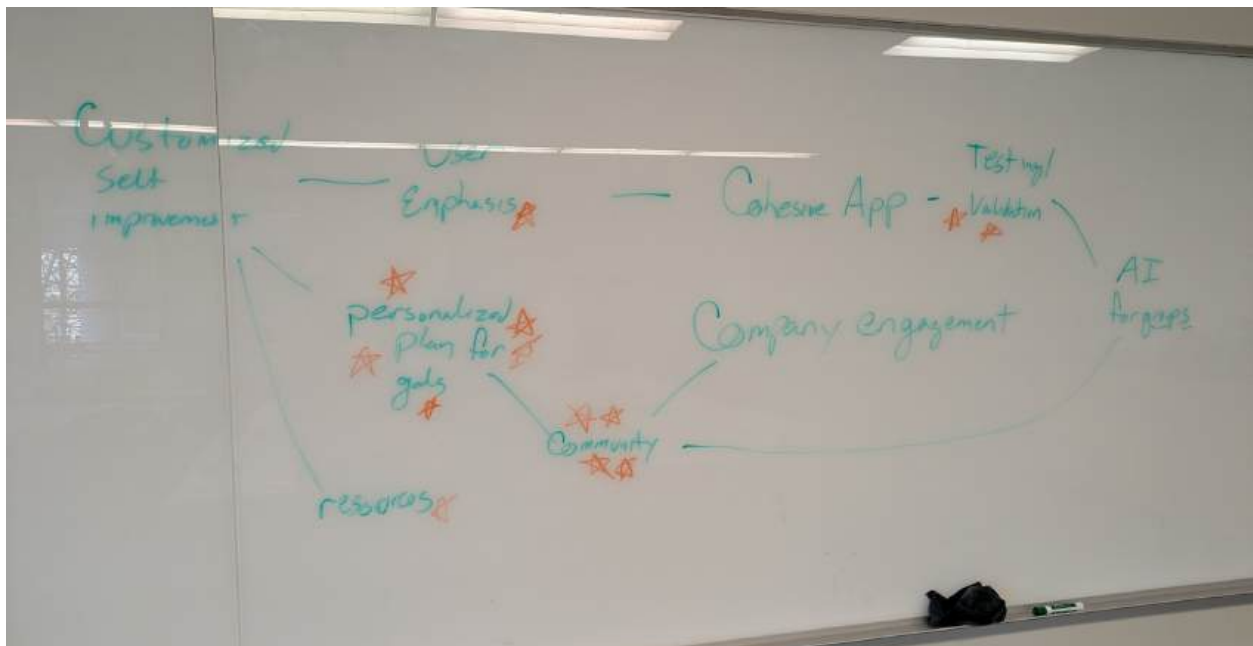


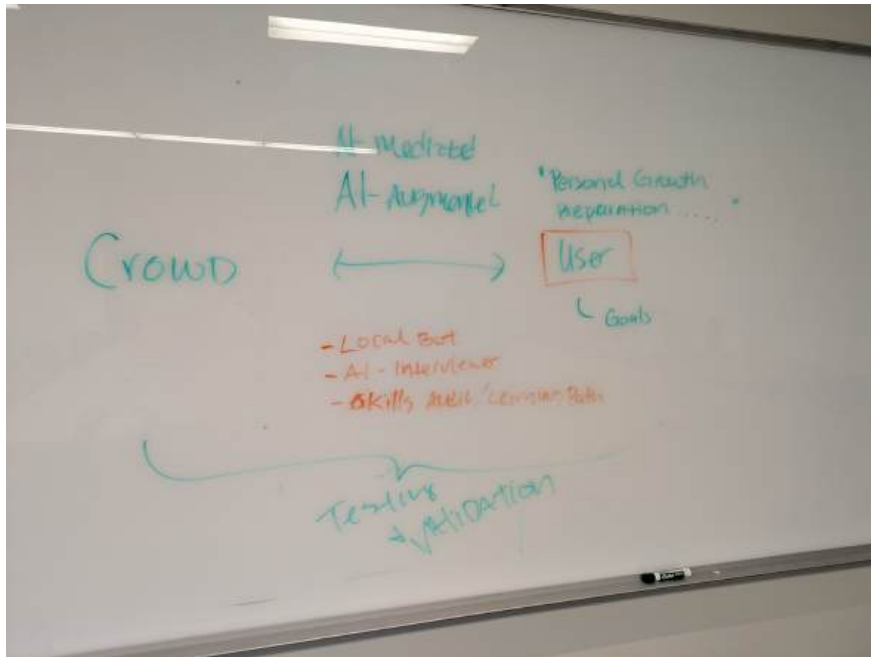
## February 3, 2026: Pitching our Ideas

### Class:

- We will be pitching what we want to do for this semester, and we should be convincing everyone in the class to do this.
- We are also making a mind map around what our ideas represent and connecting them together.
- Anita's idea:
  - Focus on taking everything we did from last semester, putting it into one app, and adding a networking/community aspect as well.
  - We should also reach out to military spouses to ask for feedback.
  - Cohesive App.
- Jesslyn's idea:
  - We should explore the community aspect, such as for example through networking with companies and career fairs.
  - Company engagement.
- My idea:
  - User emphasis
  - Testing/validation
- Teresa's idea:
  - Unified app, but then also looking at how to improve AI.
  - AI for groups. Groups with mentors and groups within mentors.
  - Idea also connects with testing/validation.
- Cyrus's idea:
  - Platform that asks about the users goals, then the app generates plans for tasks that the person should have to complete.
  - It can generate people to contact.
  - Spouses that have done the same task can comment on their experience.
  - Mentors can verify these comments and add on, which builds trust.
  - There can also be community groups that are listed that relate to their goals.
  - Personalized plan for goals.

- Community, connects to community engagements.
- Cat's idea:
  - Focus on personal empowerment as there are existing platforms for community.
  - Focus on two features, resume building, provide support for spouses on other things to help them in their career.
    - Example: help them get transportation.
  - AI should also be used for getting feedback.
  - Customized self improvement.
  - Resources.
- How do we connect the ideas together?
- Local bot
- Consider making an AI that helps with interviewing, and it gives feedback.
- Compare resumes to job posts and do a skills audit, and it can be done using AI.
- Images of the flow chart and ideas from class:





### To Do List:

- Think about several concrete goals for our idea: Personalized plan for goals.
- Think about how we can validate our idea.
- Pinpoint in Anita's diagram where this idea would go and how we are expanding upon it.
  - So go back to last time and see where we are growing.
- Go out again and be more broad about this idea in specific.
- Think of at least one idea per person.
- Write something in the Slack channel by Friday, and read everyone's post to identify what we would want to work on specifically. This can help us decide on who is doing what.

### Work on To Do:

- What I Did:
  - This week I thought of several smaller ideas we could implement for our decided on big idea.
  - I also pinpointed where in Anita's diagram this would fit.
  - I also posted earlier in Slack and saw common themes among my ideas and everyone else's ideas.

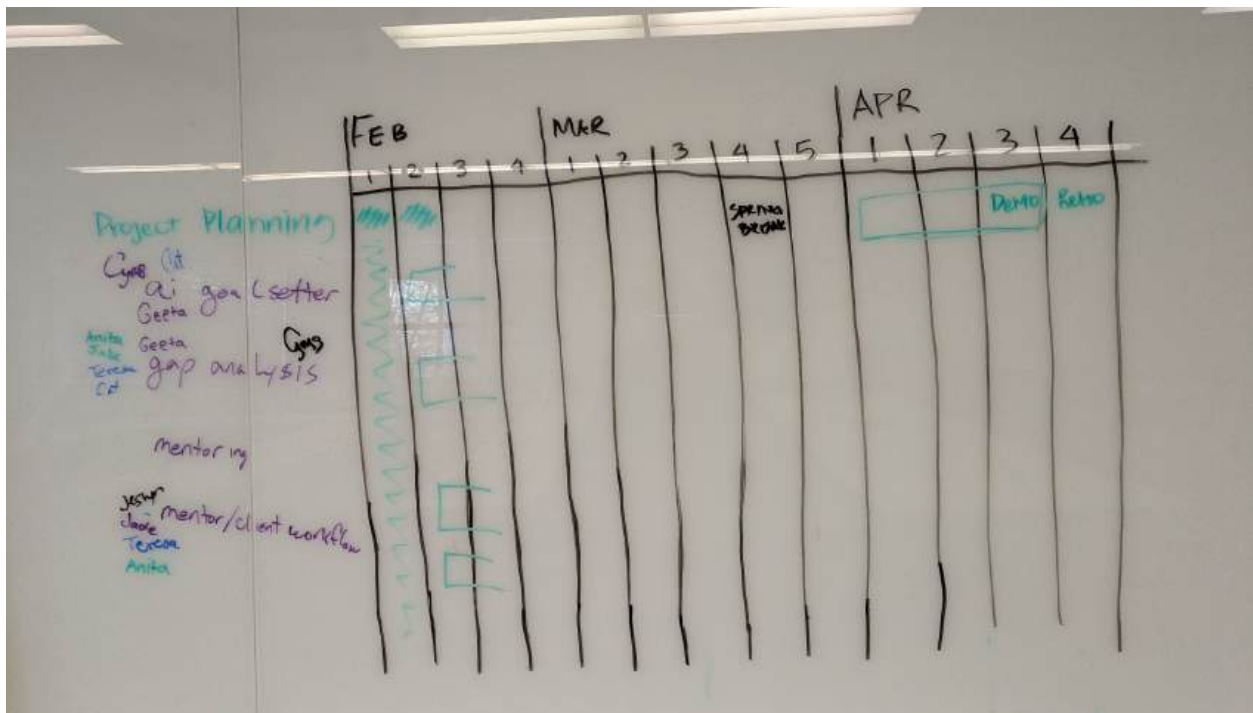
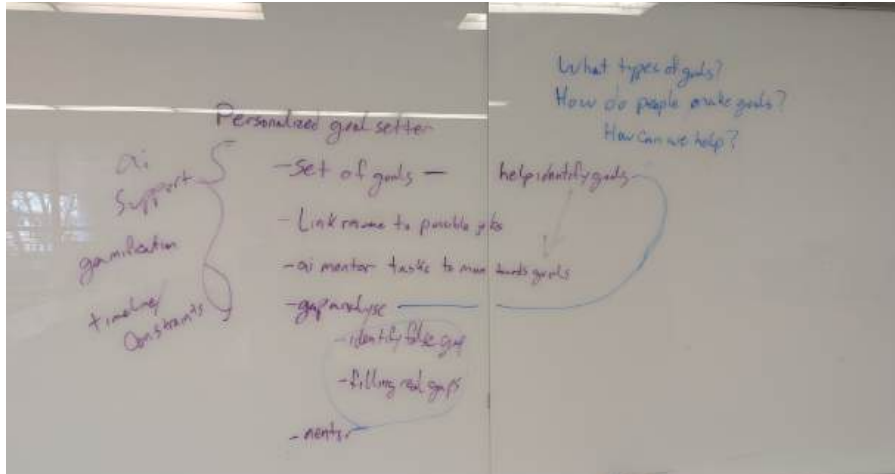
- What went well/what didn't:
    - Thinking of these ideas went well. I had a clear idea of what I would want to see in the app and what I thought would be most helpful based on the research and brainstorming we have been doing this semester.
    - I think something that could be done better is to go back and see where our work from last semester can be modified and reused so that we can move onto other tasks while some of the work is already complete.
  - Connection to overall class:
    - This contributes my ideas to what we want to work on this semester and pushes us forward into having smaller items to work on in groups.
  - Results:
    - Here are some of the ideas I thought about for the new direction we are going in for CareerCorp. Also, I think that before planning and building these ideas, we should make a new flow diagram to see how our new app will look like. This could help us organize where all the parts/features of it will look like. Currently, in Anita's diagram I think this idea would fit in the AI Chatbot and Network/Community Hub sections.
    - One idea of what to build is a personalized checklist based on the spouse's goal using AI. The AI will output a list that the user can check off when they complete it. They should also provide a due date for each task. I think to connect this to the community aspect, we can have each task linked to a chat thread, where other spouses who have done similar tasks discuss their process in completing it. If there isn't a similar enough chat thread for a task, the AI can link to an external Reddit or other discussion post that may help the spouse.
    - Another idea would be to have a separate chat page where all the users can discuss different topics in different threads. This expands upon the community idea, and even if the spouse does not currently have a goal they need a plan for, they can still come back to the app to either contribute to or look at the chat page.
  - Completion Date:
    - 2/9/26
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## February 10, 2026: Creating Big Idea Tasks for Our Idea

### Class:

- We talked about how we want to track our progress using SCRUM.
  - We either should do sprint check-ins in class or online.
  - If we do it in class, then we will have less time to talk about the issues for the things we are working on.
- We also will have a sprint board on slack so that we can know what everyone is working on and have an idea of it before class.
- We should do a stand up every class to talk about what we are working on.
- We talked about the main big idea tasks we want for the semester
  - One thing was a personalized goal setter
    - This needs to be personal to the user
    - This can be made through a collaboration of the AI and the human mentor or it could just be AI
    - We can have a timeline for each user that is personalized to them completing their goals.
    - We also want to link their resume to goals, similar to what one group did last semester.
  - Another thing was gap analysis.
    - There's two types of gaps, ones that are actual gaps and some that are false gaps that a spouse may think they have.
    - We should identify the false gaps
    - Also we should help fill the real gaps with resources
    - This can be with the mentor identifying those gaps and helping with some resources, but then it can also be supplemented with AI, which gives resources to help work on those gaps.
  - Another task is to have a full mentor/client workflow
    - We need to map out what the app will look like on both sides.
- We also started a GAANT chart with the main, big idea tasks that we want to work on for the semester. It has the weeks left in the semester and has time allotted for our demo.

- We have split into groups, where we are a part of two groups to work on these big idea tasks.
- We created chats for each group and did some discussion on where we should move forward within each group.
- Image of GAANT chart and idea brainstorming from class:



### To Do List:

- We need to decide on a SCRUM method to work.
- We should start tasks for our groups.

**Work on To Do:**

- What I Did:
  - This week, I made an AI prototype that could fit both the Goal Setter and Gap Analysis groups. This prototype takes in a user profile and mentor feedback, then it generates strengths, perceived gaps, real gaps, and next steps.
  - The prototype uses the OpenAI API, python, and flask to run locally.
  - I also added/gave feedback on our design document, figma, and roadmap.
- What went well/what didn't:
  - Creating the prototype went well. I was able to use a similar format as our group's AI feature from last time. I had to modify the prompting and what I wanted displayed in html. The prototype also shows how the two groups can connect to each other. The AI can generate goals and identify gaps using the same information.
  - One thing that needs to be improved is creating something separate for the goal setter. The rest of the group decided that having a more conversational AI would be a better path forward, similar to what one of the groups from last semester had. Therefore, I think this prototype will only be used for the gap analysis after goals have already been made through a more conversational AI.
- Connection to overall class:
  - This starts us off in the right direction for the semester. We have something to actually see and interact with given the prototype. We also have a visual with the Figma, a plan with the roadmap, and defined problems to solve with the design document.
- Results:
  - Design Doc:

# Design Document: CareerCorps Gap Analysis Feature

## 1. Purpose

The purpose of this document is to outline the design and implementation plan for the Gap Analysis feature in the CareerCorps web app for our IP Crowd VIP. This feature is intended to help users understand both perceived and real gaps in their career readiness and provide structured guidance for growth through mentor input alongside AI-supported recommendations.

## 2. Introduction

CareerCorps is building a platform to support long-term career growth for military spouses and early-career professionals through mentorship, community, and personalized guidance. One of the recurring challenges users face is not knowing whether they are truly underqualified for roles they want or simply lacking confidence and clarity. The Gap Analysis feature is designed to address this by helping users identify strengths, false gaps, and real gaps, then offering actionable steps to move forward.

## 3. Problem Statement

Users often experience friction in their career growth due to a lack of clarity around what is holding them back. This typically shows up in two forms:

- **Perceived gaps**, where users believe they are not qualified enough despite having relevant experience or transferable skills (i.e., personal child-rearing leads to good team management skills)
- **Real gaps**, where users are missing specific skills, credentials, or experiences required for their target roles (i.e., only has an accounting degree and wants to jump into data science)

Without structured feedback and guidance, users struggle to turn these gaps into concrete next steps. This leads to discouragement and disengagement from career growth tools.

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## Feature Overview

The Gap Analysis feature combines mentor-led reflection with AI-assisted guidance to provide users with a clear understanding of where they stand and what they can do next.

Key components:

- User self-assessment and goal input
- Mentor feedback and gap identification
- AI-generated summary of strengths and gaps
- Actionable recommendations for growth (HW activities, clear timelines, etc)

## Functional Requirements

- Users can input career goals, background, skills, and perceived weaknesses
- Mentors can review user profiles and provide feedback on strengths and gaps
- The system distinguishes between perceived gaps and real gaps
- The system generates recommended next steps for closing real gaps
- Users receive a structured output that includes strengths, false gaps, real gaps, and next steps

## Non-Functional Requirements

- Outputs should be supportive and encouraging in tone
- Recommendations should be accessible and realistic
- The feature should integrate cleanly into the existing CareerCorps web app
- The system should support future iteration and expansion

## User Flow

1. User inputs career goals, skills, experience, and concerns
2. Mentor reviews user profile and provides qualitative feedback
3. AI summarizes strengths and gaps and generates suggested next steps
4. User receives a personalized gap analysis summary and action plan

## Example Output (User-Facing)

### Strengths:

The user has strong communication skills, relevant past experience, and demonstrated interest in the target field

### Perceived Gaps:

The user believes they are unqualified due to lack of formal credentials, despite having transferable skills

○



- Example AI Output:

```
[
  "strengths": [
    "Strong analytical thinking",
    "Excellent organizational skills",
    "Experience managing household finances demonstrating practical financial management"
  ],
  "perceived_gaps": [
    "Feeling underqualified due to lack of formal data science degree",
    "Low confidence despite existing capabilities"
  ],
  "real_gaps": [
    "Lack of hands-on experience with SQL",
    "Lack of hands-on experience with Python",
    "No formal credentials in data science or data analysis"
  ],
  "next_steps": [
    {
      "action": "Complete an online introductory course in SQL and practice with real datasets",
      "timeframe": "1-2 months"
    },
    {
      "action": "Enroll in a beginner Python course focused on data analysis libraries like pandas and matplotlib",
      "timeframe": "2-3 months"
    },
    {
      "action": "Build a small portfolio of data analysis projects using publicly available datasets",
      "timeframe": "3-4 months"
    },
    {
      "action": "Join data analysis communities or local meetups to build confidence and network",
      "timeframe": "Ongoing, start within 1 month"
    },
    {
      "action": "Consider obtaining a certification in data analysis to formalize skills",
      "timeframe": "4-6 months"
    }
  ]
]
```

- Prototype Picture:

**User Profile**

Background: Accounting degree, 5 years managing household finances.  
 Goal: Transition into data analysis.  
 Concerns: No formal data science degree, feels underqualified.

**Mentor Feedback**

Strong analytical thinking and organization skills.  
 Needs hands-on SQL and Python experience.  
 Confidence is a bigger issue than capability.

Generate Gap Analysis

**Strengths**

- Strong analytical thinking
- Excellent organizational skills
- Experience managing household finances

**Perceived Gaps**

- Feeling underqualified due to lack of formal data science degree
- Low confidence in transitioning to data analysis

**Real Gaps**

- Lack of hands-on experience with SQL
- Lack of hands-on experience with Python

**Next Steps**

- **Enroll in an online SQL course to build foundational database querying skills** — 1-2 months
- **Complete a beginner-friendly Python programming course focused on data analysis** — 2-3 months
- **Work on small data analysis projects or datasets to apply new skills practically** — 3-4 months
- **Join data analysis communities or mentorship groups to build confidence and network** — Ongoing
- **Update resume and LinkedIn profile to highlight transferable skills and new competencies** — After 3 months of skill development

- Completion Date:

- 2/17/26

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## February 17, 2026: Review Progress and Deciding Next Steps

**Class:**

- AI goal setter:

- There may be faster ways of getting information in for the AI goal setter, like text to speech, instead of typing.
- It can also be more of an interviewer type of thing, where the AI can ask specific questions.
  - We want to ask specific guided questions to make it more structured.
- We should get research that can help the AI ask its question to structure the interaction.
- Specify what type of goals that you are helping the user set.
  - We want it to be more tailored.
- Aim for: do some research into existing ways of having these conversions (leverage it for the AI tool), what type of questions should we ask to structure the conversation.
- Also look at other databases, we may have Azure credit.
- If Firebase is the best option, justify why you use it compared to other databases.
- What type of goals are we thinking about?
  - The goal should be moving toward getting closer to achieving success in a career.
    - It should be career and job facing.
    - It can also be like you are in a job and want progress.
  - The goal should maybe look like a job description that you can imagine seeing.
  - We might want to have one big overarching goal but then sub goals within it.
    - The sub goals can be determined by the gap analysis.
- Gap analysis:
  - Step one of the gap analysis should be to take the concrete goal and decide on the necessary things you need to achieve those goals.
    - Maybe find jobs that match the goals and see what you need to get them.
    - This will create gaps.
  - There's also unrealized gaps: things that they may not know they need.
  - There should be a way to validate that what the system is recommending is actually relevant to the goals.
    - Maybe look at past successful clients and look at what they did as guidance.

- The plan is good: how we turn this into actionable steps.
  - You should click buttons to get to the resources you need.
- Open source tools are available, make some changes to them to be used.
  - Some posted on Slack.
- Aim: categorize gaps by known, unknown, and also structurally. Are they a class, experience, skill, certification? Research literature on how you can do something like this. How do you assess what perceived and true gaps a person has?
- Mentor client workflow:
  - They have a Figma with what both the mentee and mentor sides look like.
  - User flows: you should have this before the UI
    - Identify the flows, the different actors, and the different actions.
    - You want to have the phases of the workflow outlined at the top.
    - Also include the system action like AI.
    - Each action has to be supported by an input/output.

### **To Do List:**

- This week we should move forward with the work for our group.
- Here was the aim for gap analysis for next week:
- Aim: categorize gaps by known, unknown, and also structurally. Are they a class, experience, skill, certification? Research literature on how you can do something like this. How do you assess what perceived and true gaps a person has?

### **Work on To Do:**

- What I Did:
  - This week, I modified the prototype AI from last week to follow the feedback we received for gap analysis. Instead of using a user profile to generate goals for the spouse, the system now takes in the user's big concrete goal and it also looks at the user profile along with optional mentor notes. It then derives requirements and classifies them, generates goals and classifies them, and decides on next steps.

- Additionally, I also found some research on how to assess what are the different types of gaps, and the challenges military spouses specifically face with these different gaps.
  - The rest of the group also created a flow chart and looked into the research.
- What went well/what didn't:
  - Updating the AI prototype went well. I added a few more blocks of input and updated the prompt to achieve the json output that I wanted from the OpenAI API. Something that could be updated is to connect more of our findings into this prototype and have them included in the prompt. Finding the research itself went well and could be added onto.
  - Something that I could add to my work is how to validate it. I should add some validation based on how people in the past found their jobs, and if the AI recommendations align with this. I should also validate that everything the AI is recommended can be linked back to part of a job description.
- Connection to overall class:
  - This helps advance us to make our actual application for the semester. I think the research step that we have done also helps in making sure our work is based on information we found and not just what we believe.
- Results:
  - Screenshots of updated prototype:

## Gap Analysis (Prototype)

### Goal / Job Description

Target role: Junior Data Analyst  
 Responsibilities: build dashboards, analyze KPIs, write SQL queries, communicate insights.  
 Requirements: SQL, Excel, basic statistics, familiarity with BI tools (Tableau/Power BI), strong communication, some project experience.

### User Profile

Education: Accounting degree.  
 Experience: 5 years managing household finances and budgeting.  
 Skills: Excel (intermediate), communication, organization.  
 Projects: none yet.

### Known Gaps (optional)

I don't know SQL. I don't have a portfolio.

### Mentor Feedback (optional)

Strong analytical thinking. Confidence is a bigger issue than capability.

Generate Gap Analysis

### Derived Requirements (from goal)

- **R1:** Proficiency in SQL (skill)
- **R2:** Intermediate to advanced Excel skills (skill)
- **R3:** Basic statistics knowledge (skill)
- **R4:** Familiarity with BI tools such as Tableau or Power BI (skill)
- **R5:** Some project experience or portfolio demonstrating relevant work (artifact)

### Gaps

#### Known Gaps (user reported)

- **Proficiency in SQL** (skill)
- **Portfolio or project experience** (artifact)

#### Unknown / Unrealized Gaps (missing but not mentioned)

- **Basic statistics knowledge** (skill)
- **Familiarity with BI tools such as Tableau or Power BI** (skill)

#### Perceived / False Gaps (not actually required)

- **Confidence level**

### Next Steps

- **Complete an online SQL course to build foundational query skills** : 2-4 weeks
- **Learn basic statistics concepts relevant to data analysis through tutorials or courses** : 2-3 weeks
- **Explore and practice using a BI tool like Tableau Public or Power BI Desktop** : 3-4 weeks
- **Create small data analysis projects using sample datasets to build a portfolio** : 4-6 weeks
- **Practice communicating insights by writing summaries or presenting findings from projects** : Ongoing alongside projects

- Research doc:

[https://docs.google.com/document/d/18j3yi2PSSAH7fnB9ZW5vUdHrBB\\_eoSbA\\_VVUVGLE\\_Kwc/edit?pli=1&tab=t.0](https://docs.google.com/document/d/18j3yi2PSSAH7fnB9ZW5vUdHrBB_eoSbA_VVUVGLE_Kwc/edit?pli=1&tab=t.0)

- Some screenshots of research doc:

## 1.Experience/Employment Gaps

### 1.1. Known Gaps

"The average active-duty military spouse is female, 34.9 years old, has some college or a bachelor's degree, and is more than likely to have children in the home. She is four times less likely to be employed and makes about 42% less than her civilian colleagues. She has moved 3.6 times more often than her civilian neighbors, and her service member has experienced frequent deployments. This mobility and military lifestyle highlight some of the unique challenges faced by military families."

- Tenure
  - Frequent relocations (3.6 times more often than civilians) lead to recurring employment interruptions, making it difficult to build the tenure required for promotions or upward career momentum.
- Unemployment
  - While decreasing, the unemployment rate for active-duty military spouses remained significantly high at 22% as of 2019
  - "The unemployment rate for active-duty military spouses has remained consistently high over the past five years, significantly exceeding that of both veteran and civilian spouses."
  - **MINORITY UNEMPLOYMENT:** "Minority military spouses experience higher unemployment rates and lower earnings compared to their white counterparts. On average, minority military spouses earn 36% less than white military spouses."
- IVMF analysis highlights that military spouse employment is concentrated in more portable but lower advancement sectors, reinforcing experience gaps over time as spouses are less able to accumulate role specific tenure required for promotion.
- Spouses are often forced to accept jobs that don't meet their current skills because of relocation and jobs that are available in their area.

### 1.2. Unknown Gaps

- Underemployment vs unemployment
  - Refers to people who are employed but working below their qualification level
  - It is a gap that is not explicitly recognized in the literature
- Employer perception bias to hiring military spouses
  - There is very limited data on how employers view anticipated relocations in hiring decisions
  - RAND notes that employer perceptions of anticipated relocation often influence hiring decisions for military spouses, though these biases are rarely measured quantitatively, contributing to a lack of visibility around their true impact.

### 1.3. Structural Gaps

"Military spouse employment is not a story of lack of effort or qualification—it is a structural challenge shaped by mobility, caregiving, occupational segregation, and limited advancement opportunities. While progress has been made, a shift is needed—from focusing on getting military spouses "a job" to enabling them to build careers that grow across relocations, offer income stability, and reflect their talents."

- Geography (where they are located for employment)
  - Military installations are often located in remote areas that are advantageous for military activity but offer few civilian career opportunities aligned with a spouse's education.
  - "Military spouses living near metropolitan areas earn 10% more on average than those in non-metro areas."
- Childcare access gaps
- Limited access to professional networks in new locations
- RAND research reinforces that military spouse employment challenges are primarily structural, citing geographic mobility, caregiving responsibilities, and employer uncertainty as persistent barriers to sustained career advancement rather than individual lack of effort or qualification.

- Completion Date:
    - 2/24/26
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